



Northbridge Community Alliance Volunteer Matching & Communication Onboarding and Coordination Manual

Audience: Program managers and staff coordinating volunteers across tutoring, pantry operations, environmental projects, and community events.

Purpose: Provide consistent onboarding language, assignment expectations, certification rules, and communication standards for volunteer coordination.

1. Volunteer Roles and Program Areas

Northbridge uses volunteers across four primary program areas:

- Tutoring Programs (youth and adult learning support)
- Food Pantry (intake, sorting, stocking, distribution support)
- Environmental Projects (cleanup days, trail maintenance, community gardens)
- Community Events (setup, check-in, outreach tables, activity support)

2. Certifications and Requirements

Some roles require certifications before assignment. Program managers must confirm status in the volunteer roster.

Required for ANY youth-facing tutoring/mentoring roles:

- Background Check — Cleared
- Child Safety Training — Completed

Required for Pantry Operations roles that involve food handling:

- Food Safety — Basic (or higher)

Required for Driving/Delivery Support roles:

- Driver Authorization — Approved (no exceptions)

Notes: Volunteers with 'Pending' certifications may attend orientation or shadow roles that do not require the certification, but should not be assigned independently.



3. Availability and Scheduling Policies

- Scheduling should respect the volunteer's stated availability days and time blocks.
- Do not request shifts that violate a volunteer's minimum notice requirement (min_notice_days).
- Default shift lengths: 2–3 hours (pantry), 60–90 minutes (tutoring sessions), 3 hours (events/projects).
- Volunteers should not exceed their max_hours_per_week without explicit confirmation.

4. Matching Guidelines

When matching volunteers to a need, consider:

1. Role fit: skills and preferred roles align to the request.
2. Eligibility: required certifications are satisfied.
3. Logistics: availability + transportation + notice period.
4. Experience: prior assignments and relevant notes.

When multiple volunteers qualify, prioritize:

- Volunteers with the strongest role fit AND least recent assignments (fair distribution),
- Volunteers whose language skills match the audience (when applicable).





5. Standard Onboarding Language (Reusable Snippets)

Use the following language in communications to ensure consistency.

A) General Welcome / Confirmation

Thank you for volunteering with Northbridge. This message confirms your assignment and provides key details on timing, location, and expectations. If anything changes, please reply as soon as possible so we can adjust coverage.

B) Arrival and Check-In

Please arrive 10 minutes early and check in with the site lead at the welcome table. Bring a photo ID. Wear closed-toe shoes and clothing appropriate for the activity.

C) Youth Safety Reminder (Tutoring / Mentoring)

All youth-facing volunteers must have a cleared background check and completed child safety training. Please maintain appropriate boundaries, avoid one-on-one situations without staff visibility when possible, and follow site procedures for reporting concerns.

D) Pantry Safety Reminder

For pantry shifts, follow food safety guidance, wash hands upon arrival, and ask the shift captain if you are unsure about handling or storage. Some tasks involve lifting; please notify the lead if you need accommodations.

E) Photography / Media Note (Events)

If your role involves photography or media, do not photograph minors without confirming that a media release is on file. When in doubt, focus on wide shots or staff-approved moments.





6. Communication Standards

- Use clear subject lines: include program area + date + time.
- Confirm: date, time, location, role, expected duration, and on-site contact.
- Avoid over-promising; if details are pending, state what is confirmed and what is being finalized.
- Use a friendly, professional tone.

7. No Suitable Volunteer Found — Required Response Path

If no volunteer matches the required skill/certification/availability constraints, the assistant should:

- Explain why no match was found (e.g., certification missing, time block mismatch, insufficient notice).
- Suggest alternatives: adjust schedule, split the need, recruit new volunteers, or escalate to a staff lead.
- Draft a short internal note documenting the gap for leadership visibility (capacity planning).





8. Templates

Template 1 — Volunteer Outreach (Request)

Subject: [Program Area] Volunteer Opportunity — [Day, Date] [Time]

Hi [Preferred Name],

We have an upcoming need for volunteer support:

- Role: [Role]
- Date/Time: [Date] [Start–End]
- Location: [Site]
- Expected time: [Duration]

Would you be available? If yes, please reply to confirm and we'll share final details.

Thank you,

Northbridge Volunteer Team

Template 2 — Assignment Confirmation

Subject: Confirmed — [Program Area] [Day, Date] [Time]

Hi [Preferred Name],

You're confirmed for:

- Role: [Role]
- Date/Time: [Date] [Start–End]
- Location: [Site]
- Check-in: Arrive 10 minutes early and check in with [Site Lead].

[Insert relevant onboarding snippet(s)]

Thank you,

Northbridge Volunteer Team

Template 3 — Unable to Place (Internal)

Subject: Coverage Gap — [Program Area] [Day, Date] [Time]

No suitable volunteer match found based on current constraints.

Reason(s): [Certification/availability/notice/role fit]

Recommended next step: [Adjust time / recruit / escalate]

Impact if unresolved: [Brief]